GST 111 – COMMUNICATION IN ENGLISH

LECTURE 2

Developmental Language Skills

Enhanced study notes based on the lecture material provided.

Learning focus

Understand the four language skills, distinguish receptive from expressive skills, and explain the types, improvement strategies, barriers and techniques associated with listening, reading, speaking and writing.

Prepared for study and revision

1. Meaning of Developmental Language Skills

Definition:

Developmental language skills are the language abilities individuals acquire, develop and improve over time through exposure, learning, practice and purposeful use. They help people understand and produce language effectively in social, academic and professional situations.

Important point:

Language competence is not fixed. It can be strengthened through consistent practice, feedback, reading, listening, speaking and writing.

The four major skills:

Listening, speaking, reading and writing.

2. Receptive and Expressive Language Skills

Receptive skills:

Listening and reading. These involve receiving, processing and understanding spoken or written language.

Expressive / productive skills:

Speaking and writing. These involve producing language to communicate ideas, information, feelings and opinions.

Remember:

Reading is a receptive skill. The two expressive skills are speaking and writing.

3. Receptive Skills

A. Listening

Definition:

Listening is the active process of receiving, attending to, interpreting and responding to spoken messages. It is more than hearing sounds: it requires concentration and interpretation.

What effective listening involves:

Identifying the speaker's main ideas, supporting details, tone, purpose and implied meanings.

Types and purposes of listening:

- Listening for gist – understanding the general idea or overall message.
- Listening for specific information – identifying particular facts, names, dates, instructions or details.
- Listening for detail – understanding the full content and supporting points.
- Critical listening – evaluating accuracy, relevance, logic and credibility.
- Appreciative listening – listening for enjoyment, such as music, poetry, storytelling or drama.
- Empathetic listening – listening to understand another person's feelings and perspective.

How to improve listening competence:

- Listen regularly to lectures, interviews, discussions, news, podcasts and educational programmes.
- Give the speaker full attention and avoid unnecessary interruptions.
- Identify the topic, main ideas, supporting details and conclusion.

- Take concise notes using keywords, abbreviations and headings.
- Ask relevant questions and seek clarification when necessary.
- Practise with different accents, speaking rates and registers.
- Summarise what you have heard to check comprehension.
- Distinguish facts from opinions and notice the speaker's purpose, attitude and tone.

Barriers to effective listening:

- Physical noise, poor acoustics and interruptions.
- Psychological distractions, stress, anxiety or lack of interest.
- Prejudices and preconceived ideas.
- Unfamiliar vocabulary, technical terms or accents.
- Information overload and excessive speaking speed.
- Poor concentration, fatigue and divided attention.
- Inadequate background knowledge.

Key techniques for effective listening:

- Prepare by considering the topic and purpose.
- Use attentive body language and appropriate eye contact in face-to-face situations.
- Listen for signposting expressions such as "first", "in contrast", "therefore" and "in conclusion".
- Use headings, keywords and mind maps when taking notes.
- Paraphrase the speaker's point to confirm understanding.
- Withhold judgement until the speaker has completed the message.
- Ask focused questions when clarification is needed.

B. Reading

Definition:

Reading is the process of interpreting written symbols and words to construct meaning. It involves recognising words, understanding vocabulary and sentence structures, identifying main ideas, making inferences and evaluating a writer's message.

Types and purposes of reading:

- Skimming – reading quickly to obtain the general idea or overall structure.
- Scanning – reading quickly to locate specific information, such as a date, name, figure or keyword.
- Intensive reading – carefully reading a relatively short text to understand details, language use and meaning.
- Extensive reading – reading longer texts for general understanding, knowledge development or enjoyment.
- Critical reading – examining a text to evaluate its arguments, evidence, assumptions, purpose and credibility.

How to improve reading competence:

- Read regularly and use varied materials such as textbooks, articles, reports, newspapers and literary texts.
- Record unfamiliar words, check their meanings and use them in sentences.
- Preview titles, headings, subheadings, introductions and conclusions.
- Identify topic sentences, main arguments and supporting evidence.

- Practise skimming for general meaning and scanning for specific information.
- Annotate, underline key ideas and write brief summaries.
- Use context clues, word roots and dictionaries to understand unfamiliar vocabulary.
- Question the writer's claims, evidence, assumptions and conclusions.
- Discuss or explain what you have read to strengthen comprehension and retention.

Barriers to effective reading:

- Limited vocabulary and difficulty with complex sentence structures.
- Poor concentration and environmental distractions.
- Slow or inefficient reading habits.
- Lack of background knowledge.
- Overdependence on word-by-word reading when skimming is more suitable.
- Insufficient practice and limited access to reading materials.
- Failure to distinguish main ideas from minor details.

Key techniques for effective reading:

- Use SQ3R: Survey, Question, Read, Recite and Review.
- Set a clear purpose before reading.
- Adjust reading speed to the purpose and difficulty of the text.
- Pause after sections to summarise the main points.
- Use a dictionary selectively.
- Create concept maps or outlines to show relationships among ideas.
- Revisit difficult sections and check interpretations against the wider context.

4. Expressive or Productive Skills

C. Speaking

Definition:

Speaking is the ability to use spoken language to communicate thoughts, information, feelings and opinions.

What effective speaking involves:

Appropriate word choice, grammatical accuracy, clear pronunciation, fluency, organised ideas, and sensitivity to the audience and situation.

Common speaking situations:

- Everyday conversations and social interactions.
- Classroom discussions, seminars and group presentations.
- Interviews, meetings and formal speeches.
- Telephone and online conversations.
- Debates, oral examinations and public presentations.

How to improve speaking competence:

- Practise English regularly in meaningful academic and social situations.

- Read aloud to improve pronunciation, phrasing, rhythm and confidence.
- Expand vocabulary and learn how words are used in context.
- Organise ideas before speaking, with an introduction, coherent points and a conclusion.
- Participate in discussions, debates, presentations and group activities.
- Observe proficient speakers' organisation, pronunciation, pace and language use.
- Record short presentations and review clarity, fluency, grammar and organisation.
- Seek constructive feedback.
- Adapt language to the audience, purpose, formality and context.

Barriers to effective speaking:

- Fear of making mistakes or speaking before an audience.
- Limited vocabulary and difficulty retrieving words.
- Pronunciation difficulties that affect intelligibility.
- Weak grammatical control and disorganised ideas.
- Insufficient preparation or topic knowledge.
- Anxiety, low confidence or fear of negative evaluation.
- Inappropriate pace, volume, tone or register.
- Unfamiliarity with formal presentation and discussion conventions.

Key techniques for effective speaking:

- Plan the message and identify the central point.
- Use clear, concise sentences and logical organisation.
- Speak at a moderate pace and use an audible, appropriate volume.
- Practise pronunciation and word stress; the source emphasises intelligibility rather than treating accent differences as shameful.
- Use examples, explanations and transitions.
- Maintain appropriate eye contact and purposeful body language.
- Invite questions and respond respectfully to feedback.
- Adapt vocabulary, tone and formality to the audience and situation.

D. Writing

Definition:

Writing is the process of communicating ideas, information, feelings and opinions through written language.

What effective writing involves:

Generating ideas, organising them coherently, constructing grammatically acceptable sentences, choosing appropriate vocabulary and punctuation, and revising for clarity and accuracy.

Common forms of writing:

- Academic writing – essays, assignments, reports, research papers and dissertations.
- Professional writing – letters, emails, memoranda, proposals and minutes.
- Creative writing – stories, poems, plays and personal narratives.

- Functional writing – notices, instructions, applications, forms and announcements.

How to improve writing competence:

- Read widely to observe vocabulary, sentence patterns, organisation and style.
- Plan by identifying purpose, audience, main points and structure.
- Prepare an outline with an introduction, developed body paragraphs and a conclusion.
- Use clear topic sentences supported by explanations, examples and evidence.
- Practise grammar, sentence construction, punctuation, spelling and paragraph development.
- Use appropriate vocabulary and a consistent tone and level of formality.
- Revise for organisation, coherence, cohesion, clarity and relevance.
- Proofread for grammatical, spelling, punctuation and typographical errors.
- Seek feedback and use it to improve later drafts.
- Practise essays, reports, formal letters, summaries and emails.

Barriers to effective writing:

- Limited vocabulary and weak grammatical knowledge.
- Difficulty generating, selecting and organising ideas.
- Poor understanding of purpose, audience or task conventions.
- Inadequate punctuation, spelling and paragraph-structure knowledge.
- Overly long, ambiguous or poorly constructed sentences.
- Weak reading habits and limited exposure to effective written models.
- Insufficient planning, revision and proofreading.
- Uncritical dependence on digital writing tools without checking accuracy or appropriateness.

Key techniques for effective writing:

- Follow the writing process: prewriting, drafting, revising, editing and proofreading.
- Build paragraphs around a clear topic sentence, supporting sentences and a concluding or linking sentence.
- Use cohesive devices appropriately to connect ideas and paragraphs.
- Prefer clarity and precision to unnecessarily complicated expressions.
- Ensure each paragraph develops one central idea.
- Follow the conventions of the required genre and referencing style.
- Read the completed text aloud to identify awkward or unclear sentences.
- Keep a personal record of recurring errors and review it during editing.

5. Quick Comparison of the Four Language Skills

Listening:

Receptive; spoken language; understanding messages heard.

Reading:

Receptive; written language; constructing meaning from texts.

Speaking:

Expressive / productive; spoken language; communicating ideas orally.

Writing:

Expressive / productive; written language; communicating ideas in writing.

6. Revision Questions

Short-answer questions:

- Define developmental language skills.
- Name the four major language skills.
- Differentiate between receptive and expressive language skills.
- Why is listening more than simply hearing?
- Explain the difference between listening for gist and listening for specific information.
- Differentiate between skimming and scanning.
- State three barriers to effective listening and three ways to improve listening competence.
- List five types of reading and explain any two.
- State four common speaking situations.
- Identify four barriers to effective speaking.
- Name four common forms of writing.
- List the five stages in the writing process stated in the lecture notes.

Application questions:

- A student reads a passage quickly to find a date. Which reading technique is being used?
- During a lecture, a student listens mainly to understand the overall message. Which type of listening is this?
- A speaker checks whether an argument is logical and credible. What type of listening is involved?
- An assignment draft is checked for organisation, clarity and relevance. Which stage or activity in the writing process does this describe?

Answer guide:

- 1. Language abilities developed over time through exposure, learning, practice and purposeful use.
- 2. Listening, speaking, reading and writing.
- 3. Receptive skills receive and understand language; expressive skills produce language.
- 4. Listening involves attending to, interpreting and responding to spoken messages.
- 5. Gist means the general idea; specific-information listening targets particular facts or details.
- 6. Skimming finds the general idea; scanning locates particular information.
- 7–12. Answers should be drawn from the corresponding lists and explanations in the lecture.
- Application: scanning; listening for gist; critical listening; revising/editing (depending on the exact focus of the check).

7. Key Terms to Remember

Developmental language skills:

Language abilities that grow through exposure, learning and practice.

Receptive:

Receiving, processing and understanding language.

Expressive / productive:

Producing language to communicate.

Gist:

The general idea or overall message.

Skimming:

Quick reading for general meaning.

Scanning:

Quick reading to locate specific information.

Intensive reading:

Careful reading for detailed understanding.

Extensive reading:

Longer reading for general understanding, knowledge or enjoyment.

Critical listening / reading:

Evaluating the message, claims, evidence and credibility.

Coherence:

Logical organisation and connection of ideas.

Cohesion:

The language links that connect sentences and paragraphs.

Proofreading:

Checking a completed text for errors.